

Trip Report – Exploring the North – September 6-23, 2024

Nahanni river and Rocky Mountaineer have been on Safta's bucket list for a long time. Add Banff, Athabaskan Ice fields and Glacier National Park in Montana and we're off to a nature adventure for the next 3 weeks. The timing is perfect: a respite from the emotional turmoil of what is going on in Israel and reconnected with nature tranquility and beauty is what the doctor prescribed. Off we go!

Just to empty the emotional tank on the plane to Vancouver this poem came to me expressing the emotional storm that has been our daily diet now for almost a year. It reads in Hebrew.

לארצי ומולדתי

לארצי ומולדתי מכתב כמוס

בצער רב בזעם ובלב שהרוס

איך הדרדרת במדרון השנאה

איך שכחת את המצוה הנאורה

אחים היינו בארצנו האהובה

הבטחנו שלנצח נחיה באחווה

והנה בעת מצוקה סבל ומלחמה

התפוררה רוחנו הסתאבו מנהיגינו

וחלום הדורות של שלום בארצנו

את קורבנותינו היקרים כבר קברנו

את יקירינו בשבי רוצחים לא החזרנו

את הנדר לשמור על שלומנו הפרנו

אך שרים אנו עוד לא אבדה תקוותינו

התקוה שנות אלפיים ושבעים ויותר

שתקשיבו מנהיגינו לקולנו הסוער

החזירו את בנינו בטחוננו ושלומנו

ואם לא מסרו את השרביט לאחר

Day-1

We almost flunked our first test. 11,000 steps in one outing nearly destroyed us. Spectacular dinner by the water and taken the beauty of Vancouver.



Day-2

We spent the entire day at Granville Island. Why is it not the number 1 must do in Vancouver? We walked the place. Loved the Galleries especially one as you'll see here. Mom immediately picked up 3 different steel statues each she thought were representing her (mine too) three children. With tax we could pick them up for a little over $12,000. We promised to pay when we get home but the shop keeper - Israeli wanted cash now. So we took pictures and bought a lottery ticket- stay tuned. The shops, restaurants, galleries and street performers were all great. Sitting on a bench overlooking the waters was a well deserved if not earned doze of tranquility. This time the Fringe Festival is in full swing. We went to see a play: How to catch a Karen. Great one woman shows. Totally ironically about young GenZ females and their attitudes toward race, diversity and respect for prior generations. Funny ironic and makes you think. Recommended.





Day-3



We start our nature adventure in earnest this morning. Picked up and driven to a regional airport to board our flight in a Beechcraft King Air 300. On our way to Mancho Lake,BC - look it up! For all we know just before arriving at the lodge after a 2+ hours flight we may be part of a group of two. Safta and Saba. Well, we arrived at an airfield from there 3 1/2 hours by (mind you) in a luxury Mercedes RV along the Alaska Highway to the main lodge also the home of the family that owns this entire enterprise: 4 aircrafts, boats, cabins and more. A Swiss family immigrated to Canada in the 80's and built this business. Their two sons, one is a trained chef the other an electrician takes care of day trips, maintenance etc., wonderful story look it up at NRAdventures.com. Our cabin is fabulous blond wood panelling from floor to walls to ceiling. Out of our window the spectacular view of lake Mancho.



Day-4

Strike Nahani off Safta's bucket list. Today is the day. A 2 1/2 flight in a float plane over the Northern Rockies with spectacular vistas of rugged mountains and stream and ponds. We are only 5 on the trip and there is no one other than our group in the Nahani National Park (the first in Canada to be designated as a UNASCO Heritage). There are two ways to see the Virginia Falls. The hard way and the impossible way. We smartly chose the hard way watching from the top of the falls the other much younger took the other. The view is spectacular as the pictures will attest. Especially this time of year when the colours change. Lots of yellow, red and green in harmony. Safta the brave fell only twice on a long hike to the falls, but she is a lioness. There is nothing she cannot do when she wants it badly. Day 4 total of 35,000 steps.



Day-5

Today was a rest day. We still managed to clock 5000+ steps in a morning stroll on the shores of the lake. Later in the afternoon we were taken in a small power boat to a two and a half ride on Muncho lake. The female owner joined us and we soaked in the beauty of the lake the mountains with such tranquility. We can now understand why people who live and love the North are not stressed as much as us city folks. It's truly a breath of fresh air. The hospitality is first class. The food exquisite and the scenery magical. No, we are not moving as we don't fish and hunt but the stay here is wonderful.



Day-6

Today is 9-11 but you wouldn't know when you're out in the Northern wilderness. Sasha the driver and Anna-Marie the owner joined us on a road trip to Smith Falls. On the way we spotted two herds of Bisons on the side of the road and later on a Bison road kill being eaten by a flock of vultures.

The falls are majestic. Not as powerful as Virginia but beautiful in their own right. Next stop the Liard Hot springs. Natural pool of HOT water coming down from the mountain above. Like you couldn't stand near the opening of the stream and gradually as you move further out it cools gradually to a level of a hot shower at home and further down stream cools off. This is nature gift to old folks with aches and pains. The hospitality around us is uniquely first class and the food exquisite. You get a feeling that you came to a family reunion with the founder's family of Urs, Anna Marie Daniel and Michael. "Deep" conversations are not that easy unless you talk about the weather, fishing, hunting and points of interest that you'll never find on the map.



Day-7

As we “did” Nahani in the first full day we expected the next few to be so, so. But so, so they were not. Today we drove to another spectacular destination. When we arrived, we unloaded an ATV from the trailer and had a first-time experience riding an ATV. We now understand why they call it an All-Terrain Vehicle. We rode the rockiest narrow path including crossing a tiny river only to arrive at the most spectacular lake side where we (the 3 girls and the driver) lit a fire roasted marshmallows (we didn’t eat) and had some of the lodge’s famous sandwiches. New experiences every single day. But above all the views that even good pictures can’t quite communicate the OMG feeling of nature beauty and tranquility. Put another 10 on the board. Just before midnight we went out to watch the Aurora (Northern Lights). We did see some but not as spectacular as some of the pictures our driver Sasha took on August 27th. He let us have it so we pretend as if we actually saw it.





Day-8

Friday the 13th is a good time for resting our aching bodies. We were offered to take a flight over more lakes and mountains, but we declined. Just when we thought that today would be a bust Sasha offered to drive us to Mineral Lake just half an hour from the lodge. It turned out to be the most spectacular hike of some 4 km down and up. The scenery is breathtaking as you'll see in the pics. Mom made it as usual if only with difficulty on the inclines but as always job done. Likely the first- or second-best experience of the week.



Day-9

As if the weather knew it is our last day here it turned cold and grey. We were exceptionally lucky all week with good weather all days. So today we're lounging in our cabin watching TV. Later in the afternoon we were scheduled to go on yet another float plane ride into the wilderness, but it started raining (for the first time all week) so we just chilled and got ready for the next chapter in our travel plan tomorrow.

We sent this letter to the owner of the business which sums up our experience here.

Alis and I would like to thank you, your family and your staff for making our week stay at your home such a wonderful experience. We have travelled around the world in all seven continents, but seldom did we have the feeling that we are coming home to visit family. We are taken by the story of your family business but more so by the company of your parents, your staff with a special mention to Sasha with whom we spent many fun hours on some incredible excursions in this most beautiful countryside. The hospitality was first class, the food exquisite and the company so friendly. Of course, the excursions by air, foot, and ATV to some of the most beautiful places in the world including the famous Nahanni's Virginia Falls were the main attractions. We would enthusiastically recommend NR Adventures to anyone interested in exploring the beauty of the Northern Rockies.
Alis and Amnon Zohar



Day-10

Travel day. 3hrs drive to “nearest” airstrip. 2 hrs flight to another airstrip “near” Vancouver and 1- 1/2 hrs drive to our Vancouver Airbnb: small, nice, clean for 2 nights.

Day-11

Checked in to our Rocky Mountaineer at Canada Place on the waterfront. All ready for tomorrow’s train ride. Guess what? Mom insisted we go back to Granville Island and buy the metal statue we saw before. What mom wants mom gets and so we did. Then mom broke the Israeli record for the most expensive dish ever ordered by a man or woman in the over 80 class. A $145 King Crab and a Guinness to boot.

Back to our room after 15500 steps and a broken mom. At least no walking the next 2 days.

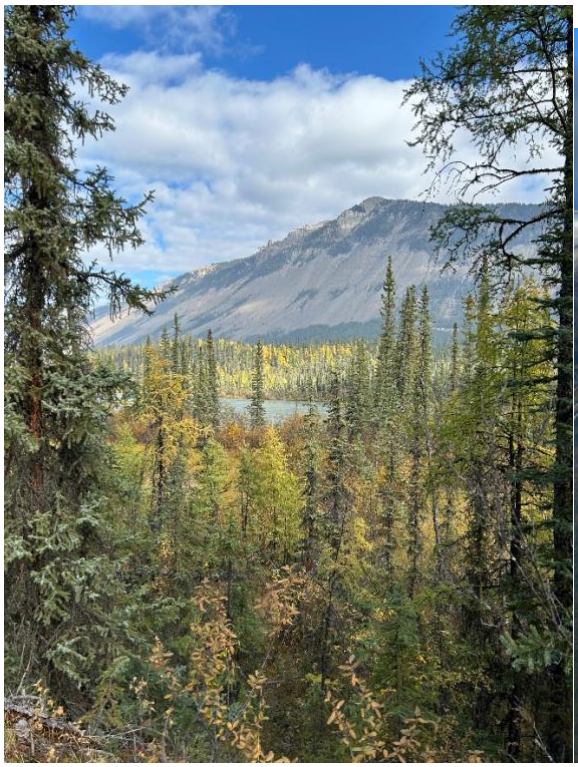
Day-12

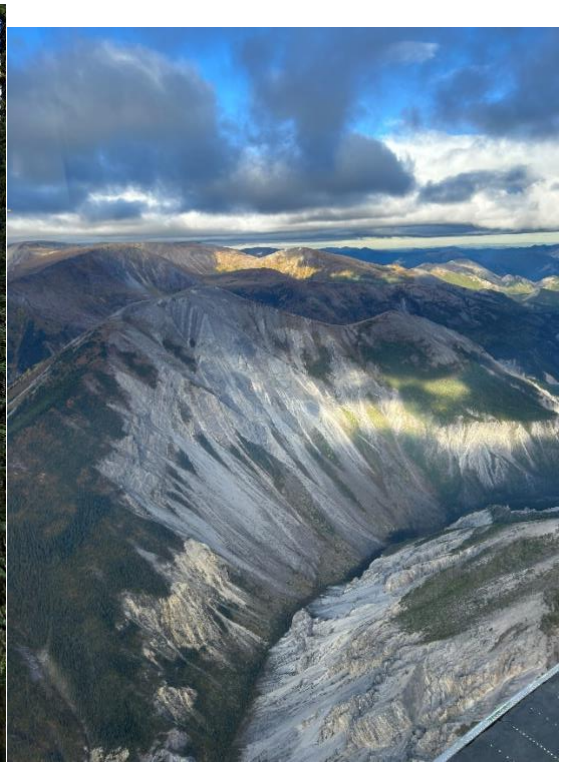
This morning we boarded the famous Rocky Mountaineer 2 days train ride from Vancouver to Banff. The first leg is from Vancouver to Kamloops. The train is first class and the food - gourmet and drinks are free and as many times. The sights from the huge windows are eye popping with as we understand even more beautiful to come tomorrow when we travel through the Rocky Mountains. The best thing today is that we don’t have to walk. It’ll destroy our average steps per day but will potentially preserve our lives, especially mom’s. 45 minutes from Kamloops the train stopped for well over an hour because of a stalled train on the tracks ahead of it. So far the only glitch in our otherwise perfect vacation so far.



Day-13

From Kamloops to Banff on the Rocky Mountaineer. The beauty of the land does not seize to amaze us. We are taking pictures left right and centre one more stunning than the others. All this in the comfort of a luxury train with a wonderful crew serving incredible food and drinks and travel guide us through the trip. What can be better? The first day was OK Good but the second especially as we entered the Rockies- SPECTACULAR!!!





Day-14

It gets only better everyday and today is the day. For the first time we are on our own. Today we (I) are driving and next to me my driving instructor from Banff to the Colombia Ice fields some 170km. Driving down this highway you get the feeling that you are on a different planet. The awesome combination of majestic mountains , turquoise lakes and evergreen forest is a painter's dream. We only took a million pictures one better than the other. The experience of walking on a 400 meters thick ice surrounded by age old ice glaciers is surreal.

Likely the best day of the trip as far as sightseeing is concerned.





Day- 15

Today is driving day. We just arrived at our (nice but not opulent) cabin near the Glacier National Park after some 400km and 5 hrs in our rented car. Driving was easy all highway traffic with thin to no traffic on it. Speeding at times in over 150 K's. As we crossed the border to Montana USA the earth turned flat and empty save some cow herds grazing. So not much today with expectations for our guided tour of the majestic Glacier National Park. Even the weather played nice with us. Today was the first cold day and it rained throughout the day but stopped as soon as we arrived in our cabin. Finished off the day with a fine dining dinner at the opulent Glacier Lodge. We may have blown our budget but we spent it on happiness! Throughout this wonderful trip we did not adversely affect the average age of our companion travellers. It seems that there are a lot of old cucker who still want to be kickers.

Day-16

Our luck with the weather continued this morning when we woke up to a blue sky sunny albeit cold day the perfect day to explore Glacier National Park.

We boarded the Red Bus for an 8 1/2 hours guided tour of this magnificent landscape. We thought that we already seen the most beautiful sites earlier on our trip but we were wrong. What we saw today can only be seen but not described for its awesome beauty. We weren't sure what we will see today. We thought Glacier ice caps. Not it. Green lush forests below spectacular mountain ranges and blue rivers and lakes in the valleys below. Even the pictures do not tell the whole story, but words would not either. Just watch. Tomorrow, we head back to Banff. We were doubting coming in if it was worth the 5 1/2 hours drive back and forth after everything we have already seen, and it is and more. Best day.







Day- 17

Heading back to Canada at the crack of dawn. So far the only down side of the trip is an estimated 10 pounds I must have gained while with all the gourmet feeding in Northern Adventure and on the Rocky Mountaineer. Back to 2 a day at home.

6 O'clock start. 6 1/2 hours later we arrived at Lake Louise. Driving was easy. But still so damn long. We have been to lake Louise before with our kids. But if you were in lake Louise before, come and come again. It is magical. More driving to Banff for our last night on this fantastic trip. Seldom do things unfold as planned and we planned well and it did work like a charm. Even more seldom does every part of the trip exceed your expectation and, in some cases, leaves you in awe especially of the beauty of

the land that only God could have created. We are tired, aching (especially mom) and so happy that we pulled it off. Finally, a shout out to Waze without which we would have been eaten by bears.

